region ended up as little more than a string of firms with Swadeshi in their names.

In another important aspect the Swadeshi movement differed from Bengal. It never slipped into a religious mode leading to the alienation of Muslims from the nationalist movement. The Hindu–Muslim riots that marred the movement in Bengal were conspicuously absent in south India.

It was against this comparatively staid background that a Swadeshi shipping company was launched. Shouting Swadeshi from the rooftops and thumping its breasts, not only did it challenge an international shipping behemoth, it also did not hesitate to take on the might of the Empire. Raising more than Rs 8 lakh in capital and purchasing two big steamers, it also succeeded in spurring the nationalist movement.

This book is the story of that heroic, if ultimately unsuccessful, effort. To reconstruct it, we must start at Tuticorin.

Tuticorin

In his verse autobiography, V.O. Chidambaram Pillai referred to Tuticorin, with some pride, by its traditional name, Thirumandiranagar, 'the town of the (*Saiva*) sacred chant'. But at the time of our story, there was little to speak for this religious pedigree.

At the turn of the twentieth century, European travellers to south India usually disembarked at Colombo. A twelve-hour-long overnight voyage on a choppy sea brought them to Tuticorin. The view of the town was, from a European perspective, 'hideous'. An Englishman, who administered the Tirunelveli district a few years after the events narrated in this book, further described it as 'a dismal introduction to the glowing East'. Cramped and huddled, the town was 'filthy' and 'dirty beyond expressing'.[13] Another European traveller, evidently turning to the south on arriving at the port, held a more flattering view: the temple tower of Tiruchendur, visible from as far as 30 km in clear weather, looked 'like a ship under full sail' at first sight.[14] Unfortunately, we have no description of the town from an Indian